‘And as far as the second part of your question is concerned, with due respect I feel that the whole issue should have been discussed with us too before the operation in Afghanistan was mounted. But Sir, now that you are in the thick of it – don’t quit, as in that case, the Taliban and Al Qaida would start believing that they have defeated the Americans too, and that they have the world on its knees,’ I said.

‘Why don’t you join us?’ Dr Kissinger asked. I replied that this question might be addressed to the right quarters in the government, as I was not the appropriate person to respond to it. I suppose he could comprehend the intricacies of our democratic set-up as is the case in the US too. During his visit to India in October 2011, the Afghanistan president, Hamid Karzai, signed a strategic partnership agreement, the first such agreement with any country. This confirmed to the world that they (Afghanistan) regarded India as a close and reliable friend of long standing. The agreement concretized bilateral relations between Afghanistan and India and envisaged military-to-military ties that would include training and supply of arms and equipment, besides the building of strategic infrastructure and facilities like hospitals.

Nepal and India share age-old historical, cultural, social, religious and economic ties. We have an open border with Nepal that facilitates people-to-people ties, trade and job opportunities. One of the pillars of strength in our relationship is the presence of about 50,000 Nepalese soldiers in the Indian army, serving in various Gorkha regiments, and around 1.25 lakh Indian army pensioners in Nepal. The sacrifices, gallantry and dedicated services rendered by Nepalese soldiers in the Indian Army are legendary. These bonds forged during peace and war can take our relationship to great heights. Besides this, many of their army officers, including the highest ranks, have been trained in Indian training institutions. These issues need to be factored into our foreign policy formulation.

Unfortunately, due to certain misunderstandings caused by political, economic or ethnic issues in the past, both our nations